



South Korea

South Korea occupies the southern half of the Korean peninsula. Under US sponsorship, it was separated from the communist North in 1948 and is now a capitalist economy.



GEOGRAPHY

Over 80% is mountainous and two-thirds is forested. The flattest and most populous parts lie along the west coast and in the extreme south.



CLIMATE

There are four distinct seasons. Winters are dry, and bitterly cold. Summers are hot and humid.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Inhabited for the last 2000 years by a single ethnic group. The nuclear family is replacing traditional extended households. Since the 1953 armistice, the Koreans have remained technically at war. Reunification is the ultimate goal, but in 2009 the South became less conciliatory and the North retaliated by ending its offer of cooperation.



INSIGHT: Half of all Koreans are named Kim, Lee, Park, or Choi



THE ECONOMY

World's biggest shipbuilder. High-tech goods and cars: rising demand from China. Strong regional competition. Aging population.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Korea

DATE OF FORMATION: 1948

CAPITAL: Seoul

POPULATION: 48.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 38,023 sq. miles
(98,480 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1268 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Korean*, Chinese

RELIGIONS: Mahayana Buddhist 47%, Protestant 38%, Roman Catholic 11%, Confucianist 3%, other 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Korean 100%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: South Korean won = 100 chon